The Global AI Power Order

National Capacity, Boundary Control, and Systemic Influence under Uneven Technological Interdependence

EXECUTIVE BRIEF

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Executive Overview

The Global AI Power Order examines why technological resources, nationally usable AI capacity, control over access, and wider structural outcomes do not necessarily coincide. Across thirteen principal national-system cases and selected cross-border relationships, it finds differentiated pathways to usable capacity and an uneven, non-exclusive international structure rather than a universal national ranking or mutually exclusive AI blocs. Its principal domain assessments support a U.S.-centered external AI domain and a distinct EU regulatory domain, while identifying a China-centered external configuration without establishing a coherent composite domain. All eight candidate Systemic Influence claims remain Not Adjudicated under the study's evidence requirements; this indicates limits on valid assessment, not the absence of consequential effects.

The Global AI Power Order develops a structural framework for analyzing these distinctions. Its central argument is that AI power operates through two analytically distinct structures: **AI National Power (ANP)**, concerning the conversion of heterogeneous resources into nationally usable capacity, and **AI Boundary Power (ABP)**, concerning effective control over another actor's access to consequential AI-related functions. The framework additionally distinguishes **Boundary Autonomy**, which concerns the credible alternatives available to affected actors and their development over time, from **Systemic Influence**, which concerns persistent, sufficiently broad, and credibly attributable structural change.

These objects interact, but none can be inferred automatically from another. Technological depth does not establish control over every consequential interface. External dependence does not necessarily eliminate national capacity or strategic agency. Effective boundary control does not guarantee target compliance or wider structural transformation. International technological reach, meanwhile, is not equivalent to the formation of a coherent geopolitical or institutional domain.

Based on comparative evidence through 30 September 2026, the book characterizes the emerging global AI power order as **uneven, polycentric, boundary-conditioned, and non-exclusive**. It is neither a single hierarchy of technological strength nor a world partitioned into exclusive AI blocs. Instead, distinct national systems, technological domains, regulatory environments, transnational networks, strategic nodes, and functional intersections organize the conditions under which AI capabilities can be accessed, deployed, controlled, and adapted.

The resulting order is identifiable but not settled. It comprises different kinds of structural organization, including national configurations, international networks, strategic nodes, and regional coordination environments, whose mechanisms and evidentiary thresholds must remain distinct.

1. Rethinking the Foundations of AI Power

The book begins by separating technological capability from nationally usable capacity. Models, compute, semiconductor production, scientific expertise, infrastructure, capital, and organizational resources can contribute to national power, but their presence or ownership does not establish operational usability. What matters is whether a national system can generate or access, integrate, sustain, and, where necessary, mobilize these resources for specified consequential functions.

ANP thus depends on the conversion of distinct resource bases into usable capacity through identifiable institutional and organizational pathways, subject to the conditions governing their practical operation. Foreign-owned infrastructure may contribute to national capacity when it is reliably connected to domestic scientific, industrial, administrative, or strategic functions. Conversely, nationally owned assets may contribute little to a particular function if they lack operational availability, effective allocation arrangements, or organizational integration.

This distinction changes the interpretation of technological sovereignty. **Substantial national AI capacity does not require complete technological self-sufficiency**, although ownership and external dependence remain consequential for upgrading, continuity, control rights, and exposure to disruption. Current operational capacity, autonomy from particular suppliers, and resilience under severe disruption must be assessed separately.

The second structure, ABP, concerns relationships rather than national resource inventories. It arises when an identifiable actor can effectively alter the conditions under which another actor obtains, transfers, integrates, deploys, or continues using a consequential AI-related resource or function at a specified interface. Such interfaces include semiconductor supply, cloud services, model access, data use, procurement, market admission, technical interoperability, and security authorization.

Formal authority, supplier concentration, or network centrality may make control possible, but none independently establishes effective boundary power. The relevant analysis must identify the controller, target, interface, affected function, applicable authority, and demonstrated implementation.

The target's position requires an additional inquiry. Boundary Autonomy concerns the capacity to create, activate, expand, or improve credible alternatives to an externally controlled interface. Switching suppliers, localizing workloads, adopting open models, developing domestic technologies, or establishing interoperability may expand feasible options. Their significance, however, depends on functional adequacy, cost, durability, and the remaining dependence on other controlled layers. The existence of an alternative at one point in time must also be distinguished from a demonstrated improvement relative to an earlier baseline.

Together, ANP, ABP, and Boundary Autonomy provide a framework for analyzing capacity, control, and agency without reducing them to a single national score.

2. Comparative Findings: Different Pathways to National AI Capacity

The thirteen principal comparative cases reveal markedly different configurations of technological resources, institutional conversion, functional breadth, and external dependence. The purposive, structured-comparative study examines five functions: commercial and industrial activity, public administration, science and education, critical infrastructure, and defense and intelligence, yielding 65 Tier A function-specific ANP adjudications. Selected boundary relations and eight candidate Systemic Influence claims are assessed separately. The public evidence is selective and unevenly observable rather than a representative sample of all national systems or AI relations. These configurations are descriptive rather than ordinal: the book does not construct a universal national AI-power ranking (Chapter 12, Table 12.4; Research Supplement S3–S4).

The United States and China exhibit broad capacity conversion across multiple assessed functions, although their institutional architectures and constraints differ. The United States combines frontier-model development, advanced computing, semiconductor design, hyperscale cloud infrastructure, research institutions, private-sector innovation, and public acquisition and access arrangements. Much of this capacity is distributed across independently governed firms and institutions rather than held under centralized state control. China demonstrates extensive system-scale conversion across industrial production, platforms, computing infrastructure, public administration, and domestic technological development, while continuing to face important upstream semiconductor and equipment constraints. These contrasts concern the organization and conversion of capacity, not merely technological performance.

India illustrates conversion-intensive AI power. Public access arrangements, software and engineering capabilities, digital public infrastructure, multilingual technologies, and organizational integration can make externally developed resources nationally usable without equivalent domestic ownership across the technological stack. Its configuration demonstrates why technological dependence and meaningful national capacity can coexist.

Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, France, Germany, and the United Kingdom demonstrate the significance of distinct forms of specialized depth. Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan contribute through different combinations of semiconductor manufacturing, advanced memory, electronics, industrial AI, and scientific or engineering capabilities. France combines model development with public research and computing infrastructure; Germany demonstrates particularly strong industrial and scientific conversion; and the United Kingdom has a research- and services-intensive configuration. These functional strengths need not establish uniformly broad national capacity across unrelated functions. The three European national cases must also be distinguished from the separate EU regulatory domain. Taiwan is assessed as a separate empirical technological and institutional case for comparative measurement; this treatment implies no judgment concerning contested sovereignty or political status.

Russia illustrates state–platform mobilization under persistent advanced-compute constraints. Continued domestic operations and selected adaptations demonstrate functional capacity under specified conditions, but they do not establish comprehensive technological independence or resilience under broader disruption.

The United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, and Qatar demonstrate differentiated capital-to-capacity conversion. Sovereign investment, energy and infrastructure resources, international technology partnerships, and dedicated implementation institutions can support operational AI capabilities. Their trajectories differ in institutional organization, industrial specialization, and technological integration. Capital commitments and announced capacity expansions must nevertheless remain distinct from infrastructure already operational and functionally usable.

Across these cases, two findings are especially important. First, technologically significant resources produce different national consequences depending on conversion arrangements and functional accessibility. Second, normal-time capability and demonstrated resilience are not interchangeable. The reviewed evidence does not establish comprehensive continuity for any case under a common, severe, multi-interface disruption scenario.

3. Boundary Control and the Limits of Technological Dominance

Access to AI-related capabilities is conditioned across technological and institutional boundaries. Export licensing, cloud contracts, data rules, procurement eligibility, market-entry conditions, and security arrangements can alter a target's permitted or feasible uses without removing the underlying technological connection.

Advanced-compute boundaries illustrate the significance of U.S. semiconductor controls, restrictions administered by other jurisdictions, supplier compliance, and technological adaptation. Their combined effects cannot be attributed to one controller merely because they operate in a related strategic environment. Legal authority, implementation, affected functions, and target responses require interface-specific assessment.

The principle extends beyond semiconductors. Cloud and model providers may restrict specified services; regulators can condition market access or data use without owning the technologies affected. Standards and interoperability can also organize participation without a unified technology stack.

Target-side adaptation complicates these consequences: operational alternatives may reduce dependence at one interface while preserving it elsewhere. Evidence for specified DeepSeek-V4-family post-training and inference workloads on Huawei Ascend supports task-level alternatives to an NVIDIA-centered pathway, but not same-condition performance equivalence, comprehensive upstream independence, or a separately measured temporal Boundary-Autonomy gain (Chapter 17; Research Supplement S2, BA-CN-ASCEND-01).

Boundary power must therefore be assessed together with the target's feasible alternatives. A controller may retain formal authority while its practical leverage changes; a target may preserve a function without acquiring reverse control; and technological diversification may redistribute rather than eliminate dependence.

4. The Emerging Geography of AI Power

The book's global synthesis distinguishes coherent domains from other consequential structures. A domain requires recurrent and persistent organization, sufficient breadth, and identifiable alignment or differentiation within a defensible functional scope. Technological prominence, geopolitical alignment, or extensive international adoption is insufficient on its own.

Table 1 summarizes the principal structural findings while preserving the differences among domains, configurations, networks, strategic nodes, and regional coordination environments.

Table 1. Principal Structural Assessments of the Emerging Global AI Power Order

Structural object	Evidence-bounded assessment	Scope and non-inference
U.S.-Centered AI Domain	**Supported** as a polycentric, non-exclusive external domain. The stricter same-function, two-U.S.-origin-layer sensitivity test is **Partially Supported**.	Recurring technological and institutional embedding does not establish unified U.S. governmental control or repeated qualifying compute–network bridges across the external domain.
EU AI-Relevant Regulatory Domain	**Supported** within the specified EU/EEA rule space through recurring participation conditions.	A coherent rule domain does not establish a unified European technology stack or regulatory diffusion beyond the originating controlled market.
China-Centered External AI Configuration	**Identifiable**; the proposed composite external domain remains **Partially Supported**.	External model uptake and selected relations do not yet establish durable, coherent cross-layer organization.
India-origin architecture and services networks	Public digital architecture diffusion is evidenced in its adjacent-DPI scope, alongside a distinct identifiable service-and-talent network. The proposed unified India Service and Language Domain is **Not Established**.	Architectural lineage does not imply continuing Indian operational control or AI-specific Systemic Influence; distinct networks should not be merged.
Gulf Capital–Compute Nodes	Differentiated and consequential UAE, Saudi Arabian, and Qatari national nodes are **Supported**. An integrated Gulf AI domain is **Not Established**.	Investment and external partnerships do not demonstrate persistent cross-Gulf functional integration or a common controller.

Structural object	Evidence-bounded assessment	Scope and non-inference
Russia's State–Platform Configuration	National configuration **Established** within evidenced functions; an external Russian-centered AI domain is **Not Established**.	Continued domestic operation does not establish comprehensive technological independence or a coherent external domain.
ASEAN Distributed Regional Coordination Environment	Institutionally consequential coordination among eleven differentiated national systems is identified; an ASEAN AI power domain is **Not Established**.	Regional coordination does not constitute pooled ASEAN ANP, a unified boundary controller, or automatically demonstrated region-wide functional overlap.

Note. Entries distinguish structural objects, not national rankings. Supported, Partially Supported, and Not Established apply to specified structural hypotheses; Not Adjudicated is a separate Systemic Influence status. The U.S. sensitivity test concerns technology-origin layers, not unified government control. Empirical cutoff: 30 September 2026. Sources: Chapters 20–22 (Tables 20.2, 20.3, 22.1) and Research Supplement.

These findings demonstrate why the number of supported domains cannot serve as a proxy for relative national power. The U.S.-centered domain and EU regulatory domain operate through different mechanisms and cannot be treated as equivalent geopolitical units. China's extensive national AI capabilities and expanding international technological reach remain consequential regardless of whether a coherent external domain has been fully established.

India-origin digital architectures, transnational service networks, Gulf strategic nodes, Russian national mobilization, and ASEAN coordination also matter without satisfying the criteria for domain formation. Their significance resides in the functions and relationships they organize, not in their resemblance to a conventional sphere of influence.

The global order is consequently **polycentric rather than territorially partitioned**. Actors may participate in multiple technological, commercial, regulatory, and institutional structures simultaneously. A national system can use technologies originating in different places while operating under distinct rules governing data, procurement, compute, security, or market participation. Such intersections create opportunities for selective interoperability and adaptation, but multiple participation does not automatically establish strategic neutrality or increased autonomy.

ASEAN illustrates this distinction. Its regional institutions support continuing AI-related coordination, while member states differ in technological capacity, industrial specialization, infrastructure development, and external relationships. The region's institutional significance does not establish pooled AI National Power, a common regional boundary controller, or an ASEAN-wide structural reconfiguration. Functional overlap must be demonstrated at identifiable interfaces rather than inferred from geographic proximity or shared membership.

5. Systemic Influence: A Higher Evidentiary Threshold

One of the book's central methodological contributions is its separation of consequential activity from established Systemic Influence.

National capacity may support external technological adoption; boundary interventions may induce organizational or commercial changes; rules and architectures may diffuse; and several mechanisms may interact. None of these developments automatically establishes a system-level outcome.

Before final Systemic Influence adjudication, the study specifies a defensible system, comparison population, observation window, and attribution target (**Scope Lock**), and establishes whether an identifiable structural change has occurred. It then evaluates **Persistence**, **Sufficient Breadth** relative to that system, and **Credible Attribution** as jointly necessary, non-scoring requirements. In this study, scope locking is

retrospective adjudicative discipline, not a claim of preregistration before evidence collection. These requirements prevent the magnitude of a bilateral effect, the visibility of a policy intervention, or technological popularity from being mistaken for demonstrated systemic transformation.

The book assesses eight candidate Systemic Influence claims. Six concern AI-specific or AI-relevant systems: China-related advanced-compute access and compliance; foreign organizational use of China-origin open models; EU AI-regulatory externalization; the DPC–Meta AI-training supervisory relationship; the New Delhi frontier-AI voluntary commitments; and the C2PA content-provenance ecosystem. The other two—MOSIP architectural diffusion and UPI–PayNow interoperability—are adjacent digital public infrastructure calibration cases, not direct evidence of AI-specific Systemic Influence.

All eight candidates remain Not Adjudicated for Systemic Influence at the 30 September 2026 cutoff. This is not a finding that their effects are absent or insignificant. Selected implementations and relationships provide substantial evidence of persistence, architectural adoption, or consequential changes in participation conditions. The remaining limits concern independently defined comparison populations, common implementation or observation windows, system-relative breadth, and aggregate attribution. Such limits are not evidence that the claimed outcomes failed to occur.

The advanced-semiconductor case is particularly instructive. Persistent changes across specified access and compliance relationships are well documented, but the available diagnostic cases do not sufficiently characterize the wider population of affected, unaffected, authorized, restricted, and restored relations. A defensible system-wide breadth finding therefore remains unavailable.

The distinction is essential: **supported structural organization is not equivalent to demonstrated, attributable systemic transformation**. Domain organization and attributable Systemic Influence are assessed through different evidentiary questions. The stated domain findings rest on their own records; they are neither established nor invalidated solely by the Not Adjudicated status of the eight candidates (Chapter 19, Table 19.3; Research Supplement S2 and S5).

6. Implications for Strategy and Governance

The framework changes how governments, firms, and research institutions should diagnose AI-related strategic problems.

For **capacity development**, the central question is not simply which technologies can be acquired, but which resource and organizational constraints prevent them from becoming reliably usable for specified functions. Public capacity builders should verify the target function, allocation rights, operational delivery, and institutional access pathways rather than treating announced compute totals as usable capacity. Procurement, institutional integration, infrastructure operation, and specialized expertise may be as consequential as resource ownership.

For **technological autonomy**, the relevant objective is not necessarily elimination of foreign dependence. Procurement authorities and dependent organizations should establish who may terminate, suspend, or move a specified workload, then examine contractual access, portability, and migration exercises against comparable functional requirements. A shift in dependence may improve feasible options even when other dependencies remain; whether it does so requires function-specific evidence, not supplier counts alone.

For **boundary governance**, effective control should not be inferred from jurisdiction, technological origin, or market position alone. Regulators and other boundary controllers should document the legal or contractual authority, actual implementation, affected targets and functions, and observed target responses separately. Such records distinguish an applicable rule from its realized effects and avoid turning a bounded restriction into a claim of comprehensive exclusion.

For **international cooperation**, technological alignment need not be exclusive. Interoperability, investment, public digital infrastructure, research collaboration, and market participation can connect independently governed systems while preserving different legal and operational boundaries. Governance institutions should also assess who can participate, contest access decisions, exit a technological dependency,

and obtain meaningful remedies. Polycentricity and interoperability do not by themselves establish equitable access or shared benefits; those outcomes require separate evidence and institutional decisions.

Finally, **claims of systemic transformation require evidence beyond adoption, announcements, and bilateral effects**. Evaluators should define the eligible comparison population before final adjudication and retain unaffected, unsuccessful, licensed, denied, and restored observations alongside prominent interventions. Policy evaluation should distinguish implementation, target response, persistence, system-relative breadth, and attributable wider outcomes. These are proposed analytical practices, not interventions independently demonstrated by the present study to improve policy performance.

These implications do not prescribe one universal model of technological sovereignty, national AI development, or international alignment. They provide a common analytical method for identifying which capabilities, control rights, dependencies, and institutional relationships are consequential in a particular setting.

7. Future Outlook: A Structured Order in Motion

The global AI power order identified in this book is a historical configuration, not a final distribution of technological or geopolitical power. Its future development will depend not only on advances in model capability, computing infrastructure, or industrial production, but also on changes in access, institutional organization, operational authority, and feasible alternatives.

Several potential shifts deserve particular attention.

The relationship between **public and private AI infrastructure** may evolve as governments expand publicly coordinated computing, procurement, research access, and national deployment arrangements while relying on privately owned or operated technological resources. Greater public involvement does not automatically establish effective national capacity or boundary control; the distribution of ownership, operation, financing, allocation authority, and termination rights remains decisive.

The increasing deployment of **agentic and action-capable AI systems** may also make execution authority more consequential. Access to a model and permission to act through tools, software, devices, infrastructure, or transactional systems are distinct conditions. Identity, authorization, tool permissions, security certification, and execution environments may become additional boundaries without necessarily displacing existing model or compute controls.

Meanwhile, **open models and distributed architectures** may change the location of dependence. Local deployment can reduce continuing provider gatekeeping for certain functions while leaving computing hardware, software maintenance, security infrastructure, or organizational access arrangements externally conditioned. Openness at one layer should therefore not be equated with autonomy across the system.

Existing domains and configurations may likewise deepen, fragment, overlap, or undergo reorganization. A more coherent China-centered external domain, closer integration among selected Gulf nodes, or stronger operational coordination across ASEAN are possible developments, but they are not established outcomes of the present study. Any future reclassification must distinguish genuine historical change from improved evidence about an earlier period.

The enduring analytical question is not which actor will permanently dominate AI. It is **how nationally usable capacity, effective control over consequential interfaces, credible alternatives, and wider structural outcomes are formed and reorganized under uneven technological interdependence**.

The evidence through 30 September 2026 establishes an emerging global AI power order that is structured but not settled. Understanding its future requires continued observation of the relationships through which technological capabilities become usable, restricted, contested, adapted, and potentially transformed into systemic consequences.

Evidence and Publication Note

Evidence and reading guide. National AI capacity: Chapter 12, Table 12.4, and Research Supplement S3–S4. Boundary-control relations: Chapters 13–16 and relevant Supplement S2 records. Boundary Autonomy and operational alternatives: Chapter 17 and Supplement S2. Systemic Influence: Chapter 19, Table 19.3, and Supplement S2/S5. Structural domains, overlap, and global synthesis: Chapters 20–22, Tables 20.2–20.3 and 22.1, and Supplement S6 for ASEAN. Timing, retrieval rules, and coding: book Appendices A–B and Supplement S1–S6. Stable chapter and table identifiers are used rather than edition-dependent page numbers.

This Executive Brief is a **companion overview** of *The Global AI Power Order: National Capacity, Boundary Control, and Systemic Influence under Uneven Technological Interdependence* and its accompanying *Research Supplement*. It reports no separate empirical investigation or additional adjudications. All contemporary classifications refer to the **30 September 2026 empirical cutoff**. Post-cutoff verification may corroborate earlier documented states but does not incorporate later outcomes into those historical assessments.

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